

Destination Discovery Map — Client Requirements

1. Vision & Purpose

The Destination Discovery Map is the **centrepiece of the RosoTravel homepage**. It replaces the traditional "browse destinations" grid with an **opinionated, recommendation-driven map** that guides travellers through a four-level decision funnel:

```
"Where should someone like me go?"  
  ↓  
"Where in this country do I base myself?"  
  ↓  
"What is actually worth my time here?"  
  ↓  
"Which version of this do I book?"
```

What This Map Is

- A **recommendation engine with spatial context** — not a traditional map
- A **preference-driven filter** that re-ranks everything on screen with one tap
- An **honest advisor** that shows trade-offs alongside recommendations
- A **conversion funnel** that moves from inspiration (L0) to booking (L3)

What This Map Is NOT

- ❌ Not a product carousel inside a map
- ❌ Not a Google Maps-style wayfinding tool
- ❌ Not a "show everything" catalogue view
- ❌ Not a separate page — it lives within the homepage section

Phase Scope

Phase	Deliverable
Phase 1	Custom flat world map (Natural Earth projection)
Phase 2	3D globe with rotation/tilt

Design Context

Important: The map section should sit together with **Travel Preferences** and **How We Do It** sections as one unified homepage block, not as an isolated component.

2. Core Principles

These seven principles hold at **every zoom level** and are non-negotiable for implementation:

#	Principle	Implication
1	A pin is a recommendation, not a location	If we have nothing to recommend somewhere, it does not get a pin
2	We reorder, we never hide	A destination that doesn't match the active preference stays on the map with an honest label and reason
3	One entity type per level	Countries don't appear at city level; products never appear on the map surface
4	Counts are ceilings, readability outranks them	Up to 8 cities, up to 4 attractions, 3 products (4 if readable). If labels crowd, show fewer — never reduce type size or tighten spacing
5	Commercial detail arrives late	Prices, ratings and review counts start at L2, complete only at L3
6	Every recommendation carries its cost	A trade-off line is mandatory wherever we make a claim
7	The map is an enhancement, not the content	The list below is server-rendered, crawlable, and the fallback when the map cannot load

3. Architecture Overview — Four Zoom Levels

Level	Entities on Map	Question Answered	Commercial Detail
L0 World	Countries	Where should someone like me go?	Pick count only. No prices, no ratings
L1 Country	Cities (up to 8, readability-capped) + attraction clusters	Where in this country do I base myself?	Counts only. Clusters show pick count, nothing else
L2 City	Attractions (max 4 winners) + categories	What is actually worth my time here?	Rating, review count, from-price per attraction
L3 Attraction	Selected attraction + siblings (3 products, 4 if readable)	Which version of this do I book?	Full: rating, reviews, duration, exact price, CTA

4. Level 0 — World

Purpose

Turn a preference into a shortlist of countries, and make the reasoning visible before anything is clicked.

Map Treatment

- **Projection:** Flat world — Natural Earth
- **Land colour:** Warm tint
- **Water colour:** Pale / muted
- **Borders:** National borders as hairlines only

- **Recommended countries:** Tinted a half-step warmer than the rest
- **Suppressed:** No provider labels, no city names from basemap, no roads
- **Frame:** Fitted to all covered destinations — no pin can fall outside the card

Pins

- **One pin per country:** white pill with coloured dot, country name, badge with pick count
- **Pill styling encodes match tier**
- **Labels never overlap:** separated in both axes; a pin that can't be placed cleanly is moved, never dropped

Panel Below Map

- Photo, match label, one reason chip, country name with top city
- "Why this fits" line
- Selection figure (e.g., "9 picks from 180")

5. Level 1 — Country

Purpose

Answer "where in this country" before anyone starts comparing tours.

Map Treatment

- **Projection:** Switches to **Mercator**, fitted to selected country
- **Selected country:** Filled a shade darker than neighbours — boundary of decision is obvious
- **Surrounding countries:** Visible but unlabelled

How Many Cities

Hard ceiling: 8 cities. Readability decides the real number.

- Add cities while every label still sits clear of its neighbours at **390px viewport**
- Ranking is by **decision value**, not catalogue size
- **Top-ranked city is emphasised** — default choice is never ambiguous

Pin Behaviour Under Crowding

- Lower-ranked cities drop their **count badge** first
- If still crowded, lower-ranked cities drop their **label**
- If still can't be placed cleanly, city is held back from the map → stays in panel list (never lost)

6. Level 2 — City

Purpose

Show the two or three things in this city that we would actually send this traveller to, and start being specific about money.

Map Treatment

- **Surface:** Light dotted field
- **City centre:** Marked with a dot
- **Distance rings:** Concentric rings from centre
- **Scale bar:** In kilometres
- **City name:** Set small beneath centre dot
- **Attraction positions:** True coordinates — geography is real even though basemap is quiet

How Many Attractions

Maximum: 4 winners per city. Not 4 of everything — 4 genuinely relevant to the active preference.

- Ranked by **review volume within their category** — ordering is earned by evidence

Panel

- Photo, match label, reason chip (assembled from verified product facts)
 - Attraction name + category
 - Fit explanation
 - **Rating, review count, from-price** (commercial detail starts here)
 - One trade-off line closes the list
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7. Level 3 — Attraction & Products

Purpose

Make the booking decision between two or three versions of the same attraction, and be explicit about what each one gives up.

Map Treatment

- **Frame:** Stays at **city scale** — context is what makes comparison possible
- **Selected attraction:** Emphasised
- **Sibling attractions:** Visible in quieter treatment (paler fill/border, **never faded text**), remain tappable
- **Switching:** One tap to switch between attractions

How Many Products

Cap: 3 products. A 4th is allowed only where the card set still reads cleanly.

- 3 genuinely different options beat 4 near-identical ones
- **Duplicates are removed before the cap is reached**
- Each product must differ on something actionable: **duration, access level, price bracket, or group size**

Product Card — Panel

1. Photo + title
 2. Fact row: rating, review count, duration, exact price
 3. **Why this fits** — assembled from approved template + verified product facts
 4. **Material trade-off** — in quiet grey block
 5. **Review prioritisation block** — preference-filtered review slice
 6. **Single priced CTA** — **Check dates** · **from €49**
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8. Preference Row — The Only Input

A single horizontally scrolling row of **preference chips** sits above the map.

Behaviour

- **Tap a chip:** Re-ranks pins, re-tints map, rewrites every match label, reason chip, fit explanation, trade-off. Reorders the list below. Updates count line above map
 - **One selection at a time:** Selected chip = solid navy fill
 - **Poor fit on current view:** If currently open destination is a poor fit for the new preference → **view returns to World level** rather than leaving someone inside a recommendation we no longer stand behind
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9. Match Labels & Reason Chips

Match Label System

- **Best match:** Solid red, white text
- **Best alternative:** White with navy outline
- **Also fits:** Warm grey fill, no border
- **Worth considering:** White with dashed border

Reason Chips

Reason chips name **specific reasons, never moods** (e.g., "Strong family-compatible inventory" instead of "Perfect for families").

- **One chip per row** on the map panel
 - **Two maximum** on an attraction row
 - Where a chip states a format or duration → **derived from real product data**, can never contradict the product list underneath
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10. Trade-offs & Review Prioritisation

Material Trade-off

Every country, city, and product carries **one trade-off**. It must be **material** — something that would change a decision.

- Never a disclaimer, never legal small print

Review Prioritisation Block

- Label **changes with the preference row** — same product can honestly show a different review slice to a family vs. a culture traveller
- Contextual snippet explains **why these reviews** were selected

11. Navigation Between Levels

Movement Rules

- **↓ Down:** Tap a pin or panel row (Descends one level)
- **↓ Down:** Zoom in (Same as tap — chooses highest-ranked entity in view)
- **↑ Up:** Zoom out (Climbs one level, drops the selection it leaves behind)
- **↑ Up:** Breadcrumb tap (Any level is one tap away)
- **↔ Pan:** Drag (**Never changes level, never opens anything**)

Transition Feedback

Each transition confirms itself with a brief line over the map (e.g. "Poland · 5 cities prioritised", "Re-ranked for culture & history"). States **what changed**, never "loading".

12. States to Design

- **Poster / First Paint:** Map loads behind a static poster — it never blocks the first render.
- **Single-Match Preference:** When only one destination is a strong match, map still frames all covered destinations. Must never collapse onto one point or come back empty.
- **No Map (Fallback):** The crawlable list below is the section. Same match labels, same order, real links.
- **Empty Photography:** Every image is a drop slot until real photography lands. **No stock, no illustration, no AI imagery.**
- **Loading Level:** Brief skeleton matching target level's layout. Transition feedback line appears immediately.
- **Error:** Map degrades to list gracefully. No error modals over the map surface.

13. Non-Negotiables

Constraint	Specification
Touch targets	44px minimum for every control. Map pins stay visually small; a tap within 22px resolves to nearest pin
Contrast	4.5:1 on all functional text, including match labels and smallest metadata. De-emphasis via fill and border, never by fading text
Basemap	Own vector geometry, RosoTravel styling. No third-party map branding , no provider POI labels anywhere on the surface

Constraint	Specification
Section height	Map roughly 200px on a 390px screen , with one results panel that scrolls internally. Descending a level must not lengthen the page
Indexability	Ranking and copy adapt to preference; the page's indexable structure and routing targets do not . Preference is a session signal, never a URL